

TERROR TARGETS

In all the blasts across three cities in the past three years, clues pointed to the involvement of SIMI

MUMBAI

■ A series of seven bombs went off in crowded local trains during the evening rush hour within 30 minutes

NEHA NATH

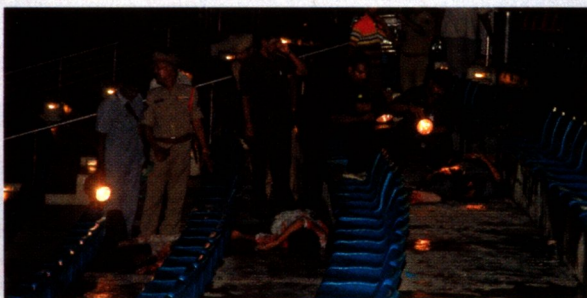


on July 11, killing nearly 200 people and injuring 700. All the bombs were placed in first class coaches and were packed in pressure cookers with 2.5 kg RDX each. The bombs were assembled at Govandi by a specialised team of Pakistani and Indian nationals. SIMI was involved as a support group to carry out the bombings.

HYDERABAD

■ Three months after the Mecca Masjid blasts in the city, a bomb went off at Lumbini Park on August 26, killing 10 people and injuring 29. Five minutes later, an explosion ripped

through an eatery, killing 32 people and wounding 71. The blasts were triggered by cell phone timers. Hours later, a live bomb was found in Dilsukhnagar and defused.



JAIPUR

■ On May 14, eight bombs went off within 15 minutes in busy markets, killing over 80 and injuring more than

150 people. The bombs were planted on cycles and cycle rickshaws and were designed to cause maximum damage. Four bombs were defused in time, saving further tragedy. In August, SIMI activist Mufti Abu Bashir confessed that he had masterminded the Jaipur and Ahmedabad blasts.



mafia gangs and for terrorist outfits, who are swelling their cadres from this district.

The countdown to solving the Ahmedabad blasts case began on July 29 when a shaken Muslim in Bharuch took a morning bus to Ahmedabad. He went straight to Crime Branch officials and told them that he had seen the two Maruti cars used in the blasts being driven by four Muslim youth. They had been tenants at his two-storey house for a couple of months before vacating it a few days before the blasts. He identified the cars from their numbers published in newspapers on the third day of the blasts. Police traced the calls on his mobile and tracked down one of the tenants' number. They later discovered that he was Tauqir. Next was a tip-off from the Central Intelligence Bureau that an old SIMI worker called Zahid Sheikh who lived in Juhapura in Ahmedabad could be a prime suspect. He was picked up on August 3. On the third day during intense interrogation, he confessed to his involvement in the blasts and named SIMI activists from Ahmedabad, Vadodara and Bharuch.

Simultaneously, monitoring of the phone calls of some Vadodara-based SIMI suspects and intense vigil at the behest of Police Commissioner Rakesh Asthana revealed vital clues. In Ahmedabad, the police picked up Yunus Mansuri, 31, a stationery and grocery shop owner; Samsuddin Sheikh, 32, a sewing thread seller; Mohammed Arif Kagzi, 34, a former Arabic teacher; Gyasuddin Ansari, 29, a senior SIMI activist and garment store owner along with an embroidery worker.

In Vadodara, Imran Sheikh, 34, who has done a course in journalism and human rights from MS University, was detained. So were Usman Agarbattiwala, 24, a commerce graduate, and Iqbal Sheikh, 20. Sajid Mansuri, a notorious SIMI leader who had been absconding since 2001 in a case of anti-national activity registered against SIMI in Surat, was picked up in Bharuch. He also figures in the Jaipur blasts case. Iqbal was with him on May 13 in Jaipur when the blasts rocked the city. But the most important names that were revealed during the interrogation of Zahid and Yunus were those of Bashir and Tauqir. The cross-questioning threw up the involvement of SIMI activists who attended terror camps in the Wagamon jungles of Kerala in December and in Pavagadh jungles near Vadodara in January last but were not directly involved in the